

Food & Meal Expense Policy

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Document status: Detailed fictional enterprise reference policy for RAG development and testing.

Important: This document is a reference policy, not an actual policy issued by a specific company. Replace rates, approval authorities, tax treatment and local requirements with your organization's approved rules before production use.

Purpose

Defines eligibility, meal limits, business-meal requirements, documentation and exceptions.

1. Scope and Definitions

Applies to employees, contractors and other workers who incur authorized business travel expenses.

1.1 Business Travel

Business travel means travel away from an employee's normal work location for an approved business purpose.

1.2 Policy Principles

- Expenses must have a legitimate business purpose.
- Employees must use reasonable and economical options.
- Expenses must be submitted accurately and on time.
- Duplicate reimbursement is prohibited.
- Falsified or altered receipts may result in disciplinary action.

2. Roles and Responsibilities

Employee

- Obtain required approval.
- Use approved suppliers where available.
- Retain receipts and supporting evidence.
- Submit complete and accurate claims.
- Repay unused advances or personal amounts.

Manager

- Confirm business purpose and necessity.
- Review reasonableness and documentation.
- Approve exceptions only within delegated authority.
- Escalate suspected fraud.

Finance

- Maintain controls and audit procedures.
- Validate claims.
- Process approved reimbursement.
- Maintain records under retention requirements.

3. Meal Eligibility

Meals are reimbursable when incurred during authorized business travel or qualifying business activities.

Meal Categories

- Breakfast during qualifying travel.
- Lunch during a business travel day.
- Dinner when the employee remains away through the evening.
- Business meals involving customers or other external contacts, subject to additional documentation.

4. Illustrative Meal Limits

Location	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner	Daily reference cap
India	INR 500	INR 800	INR 1,200	INR 2,500
USA	USD 20	USD 35	USD 60	USD 115
UK	GBP 15	GBP 25	GBP 45	GBP 85
Singapore	SGD 20	SGD 35	SGD 60	SGD 115

These figures are illustrative and must be replaced with the organization's approved rate table.

5. Per Diem vs Actuals

Where per diem is used, employees generally should not claim actual meal receipts for the same meal. Where actual reimbursement applies, claims are limited to documented eligible costs up to the applicable limit.

6. Business Meals

- Record date, location, business purpose, host and attendees.
- Alcohol is not reimbursable unless expressly permitted by a separate hospitality policy.
- Tips/service charges may be reimbursable where customary and reasonable.
- Entertainment unrelated to business purpose is excluded.

7. Group and Client Meals

One employee should normally submit a group meal claim when acting as host. Attendees or attendee categories and business purpose should be recorded. The same receipt must not be claimed twice.

8. Special Dietary Requirements

Reasonable additional costs arising from documented business or medical dietary requirements may be reimbursable when approved. Personal preference alone does not create an exception.

9. Non-Reimbursable Meals

- Meals for family or friends without business purpose.
- Alcohol where prohibited.
- Meals already included in a conference or hotel package.
- Personal minibar charges.
- Fines or penalties.

10. Receipts and Missing Receipts

Itemized receipts should be retained. If unavailable, use the missing-receipt declaration process and provide vendor, date, amount, currency and business purpose. Repeated missing receipts may receive additional review.

11. FAQs

Can I claim dinner if the hotel provides dinner?

Normally no if the meal has already been provided as part of the hotel arrangement.

Can a client dinner exceed the employee meal limit?

Potentially, if the business-meal policy and approval matrix permit it.

Can two employees claim the same bill?

No, unless the system supports an auditable split allocation.